

The Zune Marketplace

The Zune Marketplace is Microsoft's online store for digital music (purchase), music videos (purchase), TV shows (purchase and rent), movies (purchase and rent), and podcasts (free, and in audio and video forms). While the Zune Marketplace browsing experience is generally better on the PC using the Zune PC software, Microsoft does provide a basic interface to the Zune Marketplace on Windows Phone devices as well. This section quickly takes a look at both.

Zune Marketplace on the PC

On the PC, the Zune Marketplace is accessed via the excellent Zune PC software. This software provides a graphically rich way to discover new music, TV shows, movies, and other content. For the most part, purchasing content in Zune Marketplace on the PC is straightforward. There are, however, a few things you should know about.

- ▶ **Microsoft Points:** Inexplicably, Microsoft doesn't typically price items in the Zune Marketplace using dollars or local currency as they do on the device. Instead, the company forces you to use a micropayment system called Microsoft Points that has its own exchange rate. You can pre-purchase Microsoft Points in bundles of various amounts (where 400 Microsoft Points is \$4.99 in the United States, 800 Microsoft Points is \$9.99, 1600 Microsoft Points is \$19.99, and 4000 Microsoft Points is \$49.99). Or, if you don't have enough in your account to cover a purchase, you can buy them on the fly during your purchase.
- ▶ **So what's the price? And can I buy or rent?** And speaking of issues with buying content, Zune Marketplace often doesn't advertise the price of an item up front. This is particularly problematic with movies. Some movies are available for rent only. Some can be purchased or rented. And some movies can be purchased in High-Definition (HD) or standard definition (SD) formats. You won't know until you really dive in. And even then, you won't know what the price is until you click on the Buy or Rent button.
- ▶ **Rental silliness:** When you attempt to rent a movie, you're presented with the bizarre screen shown, though your own experience might admittedly be less confusing if you have fewer compatible devices. Unlike with Apple's iTunes Store, when you rent a movie from Zune Marketplace,